



Maison Amarine

THE ACADEMY

WEEK 1 · MODULE 5 OF 5

The Ladders of the House

HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

A short module, and an important one. Its only job is to place you honestly on the map of this profession — to show you both ladders of the house, where each begins, and how a person climbs from one to the other. Read it once. You will refer back to it when you plan your own next step.

The ladders of the house

Where domestic service sits, where the management of a life sits, and how one becomes the other

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Map the whole field of private service without snobbery and without illusion. Place domestic staffing and household management on the same ladder rather than in separate worlds. And see the concrete path from one to the other, so you know both where you are and where you are going.

1.1 · TWO LADDERS, ONE HOUSE

Every private household is run by two kinds of people, and both are private service.

DEFINITION

Domestic staffing. The roles organised around the maintenance of the house — housekeeper, cook, driver, nanny, gardener, laundress, houseman. Skilled, essential, honourable, and paid for the doing of the work itself, done superbly.

DEFINITION

Household management. The roles organised around the management of a life — house manager, estate manager, private PA, chief of staff, and the butler in its senior sense. Paid not for a task but for judgement, discretion, and the running of the whole.

Same world. Same principal. Same discretion demanded of everyone. A different rung, and a different thing being sold.

1.2 · NEITHER IS ABOVE THE OTHER

It is tempting, and wrong, to read one ladder as higher than the other. The management tier is paid more and carries more risk, but it stands on ground the domestic staff lay every day, and it knows it. The finest house managers are almost always people who came up through a domestic role, because they learned the house from the inside before they were asked to run it. A manager who looks down on the housekeeper has already failed at the one thing the role is for: holding a house together.

1.3 · THE CLIMB, IN PRACTICE

You move from doing to running, and the move is made in small, visible steps rather than a single leap.

- You take on coordination no one asked you to take: the diary, the deliveries, the rota, the supplier who keeps letting the house down.
- You write things down — how the house actually runs — until you are the person who knows, and the house is easier because of you.
- You learn the numbers: what things cost, how a household budget is kept, why a spend must always be explainable.
- You earn the family office's trust, quietly, until it is you they call when something is complicated.
- And one day you are managing, because you were already doing it, and someone finally paid you for it.

The whole board

Why you must know every role in a family office, not only your own

You cannot run a life you do not understand, and a life at this level is run by many hands. Whatever rung you stand on, you are judged on whether you know the whole board — who every person is, what they do, and where a thing goes when it leaves your hands. A manager who cannot tell the family office controller from the principal's private PA will send the wrong thing to the wrong person on the wrong day, and be remembered for it.

Learn all of it, on both sides.

The family office — the private structure that runs the family's affairs and money.

- The **family office director** — runs the office; often your true employer.
- The **chief of staff** — the principal's right hand across business and private life; frequently the person you report to.
- **Controllers and accountants** — the money: budgets, payroll, and the invoices you must be able to explain.
- **Private PAs and EAs** — the principal's diary and correspondence; your closest daily counterpart.

- **In-house counsel, investment and tax advisers** — you rarely deal with them, but you must know they exist and never cut across them.

The household — the people who run the residences and the life inside them.

- **Estate manager** — runs several properties, their staff and budgets.
- **House manager** — runs a single residence and its staff.
- **Butler** — the senior of formal service, front of house.
- **Head housekeeper and housekeepers** — the condition of the house.
- **Private chef** — the table.
- **Chauffeur, nanny or governess, security, grounds and gardens** — each a craft of its own.

THE RULE

Know every seat at the table, what it does, and who it answers to — the ones far above you and the ones far below. The person who knows only their own job is a member of staff; the person who knows the whole board is the one they promote to run it.

Where this programme takes you

This academy trains for the **management tier** — the person these families choose to run a life, the most discreet and best-paid role in the house. That is a deliberate choice, and it shapes everything you will learn here.

But the two ladders are one profession. If you begin in a domestic role, this is your route up, written down and made deliberate. If you begin here, this is the ground you are standing on, and the people you will one day lead. Respect both, and you will rise; forget either, and you will not.

Glossary of the module

Domestic staffing — roles organised around maintaining the house. **Household management** — roles organised around running a life. **Housekeeper, cook, driver, nanny, gardener** — the core domestic roles. **House manager, estate manager, private PA, chief of staff** — the core management roles. **The family office** — the private structure that manages a family's affairs, and often the party that hires, keeps and promotes you.